Black Mother Praying

By Owen Dodson

INTRODUCTION

In this selection a mother, examines the negative situation that her sons will face as they return home from war. Through her examination of the society in which she lives, she uncovers the powerful contradictions found in a racist society during wartime. She is very outspoken in her awareness of the unfair treatment of black soldiers who are sent overseas to guarantee freedoms in which they do not even have at home. Her out lash at the severity of racism at home is the significant base for her dissent and examination of her own son's purpose and role in war. She correlates racism directly with "hate" and shows how there isn't any real freedom where hate abides. Black Mother Praying by Owen Dodson is dedicated to Negro mothers everywhere and especially to his own mother, Lillian C. Dodson

My great God, You been a tenderness ta me,

Through the thick and through the thin;

You been a pilla ta my soul;

You been like the shinin light a morning in the black dark,

A elevator ta my spirit

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Now there's a fire in this land like a last judgment,

And I done sat down by the rivers a Babylon

And wept deep when I remembered Zion,

Seein the water that can't quench fire

And the fire that burn up rivers.

Lord, I'm gonna say my say real quick and simple:

You know bout this war that's bitin the skies

And gouging out the earth.

Last month, Lord, I bid my last boy away ta fight.

I got all my boys fightin now for they country.

Didn't think bout it cept it were for freedom

Didn't think cause they was black they wasn't American;

Didn't think a thing cept that they was my only sons.

And there was mothers all over the world

Sacrificin they sons like You let Yours be nailed

To the wood for men ta behold the right.

Now, I'm a black mother, Lord, I knows that now,

Black and burning in these burnin times.

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I can't hold my peace cause peace ain't fit ta mention
When they's fightin right here in our streets
Like dogs – mongrel dogs and hill cats.
White is fightin black right here
Where hate abides like a cancer wound
And Freedom is writ big and crossed out:
Where, bless God, they's draggin us outta cars
In Texas and California, in Newark, Detroit,
Blood on the darkness, Lord, blood on the pavement,
Leavin us moanin and afraid.
What has we done?
Where and when has we done?
They's plantin the seeds a hate down in our bone marrow
When we don't want ta hate.

We don't speak much in the street where I live, my God,
Nobody speak much, but we thinkin deep
Of the black sons in lands far as the wind can go,
Black boys fightin this war with them.
We thinkin deep bout they sisters stitchin airplane
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And they old fathers plowin for wheat
And they mothers bendin in wash tubs,
They brothers at the factory wheels.
They all is bein body beat and spirit beat
And heart sore and wonderin.

Listen, Lord, they ain't nowhere for black mothers ta turn.
Won't You plant Your Son's goodness in this land
Before it too late?
Help these men ta see they losin while they winnin
Long as they allow theyselves ta lynch
In the city streets and on country roads?

When can I pray again,
View peace in my own parlor again?
When my sons come home,
How can I show em my broken hands?
How can I show em they sister's twisted back?
How can I present they land ta them?
How, when they been battling in far places for freedom?

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Better let em die in the desert drinkin sand
Or holdin onta water and shippin inta death
Than they come back an see they sufferin for vain.

I done seen a man runnin for his life,
Runnin like the wind, from a mob, ta no shelter.
Where were a hidin place for him?

Saw a dark girl nine years old
Cryin cause her father done had
The light scratched from his eyes in the month of June.
Where the seein place for him?
A black boy lyin with his arms huggin the pavement in pain.
What he starin at?
Good people, hands up, searched for guns and razors and pipes.
When they gonna pray again?

How, precious God, can I watch my son's eyes
When they hear this terrible?

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How can I pray again when my tongue
Is near cleaving to the roof of my mouth?
Tell me, Lord, how?

Every time they strike us they striking Your Son;
Every time they shove us in, the cornerin they own children.
I'm gonna scream before I hope again.
I ain't never gonna hush my mouth
Or lay down this heavy, black, weary, terrible load
Until I fights ta stamp my feet with my black sons
On a freedom solid rock and stand there peaceful
And look out into the star wilderness of the sky
And the land lyin about clean, and secure land,
And people not afraid again.

Lord, let us all see the golden wheat together,
Harvest the harvest together
Touch the fullness and the hallelujah together.

Amen

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SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

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